

TABLE 5

Effective Treatments for Cold Symptoms in Children

Treatment	Age of participants	Dosing	Duration of treatment	Study findings
Acetylcysteine	0 to 18 years	Varies	Variable, up to 28 days	Cochrane review of 6 low- to moderate-quality trials (N = 497) found small reduction in cough at day 7 vs. placebo ⁴¹
Analgesics	0 to 18 years	Acetaminophen: 15 mg per kg Ibuprofen: 5 to 10 mg per kg	Variable during symptoms	Cochrane review of 6 low- to moderate-quality studies (N = 915) found that acetaminophen and/or ibuprofen lowers temperature and may result in less discomfort ⁵⁹
Honey	2 to 5 years 6 to 11 years 12 to 18 years	2.5 mL 5 mL 10 mL	Once Once Once	2 Cochrane reviews and 1 RCT found significant reduction in symptoms ^{6,60,61}
Intranasal ipratropium (Atrovent)	5 to 11 years	2 sprays (0.03% or 0.6%) per nostril 3 or 4 times per day	First 2 to 3 days of symptoms	Cochrane review of 7 RCTs (N = 2,144) without meta-analysis showed significant reduction in rhinorrhea but not nasal congestion vs. placebo ⁶²
Nasal saline irrigation	6 to 10 years	3 to 9 mL per nostril	Up to 3 weeks	RCT (N = 401) showed improved resolution of nasal symptoms; reduced use of antipyretics, mucolytics, and antibiotics; and fewer days missed from school ($P < .05$ for all) ⁶³
Ointment containing camphor, menthol, and eucalyptus oils	2 to 5 years 6 to 11 years	5 mL 10 mL	Once Once	RCT (N = 138) found reduced cough, congestion, and sleep difficulty compared with petrolatum ointment or no treatment ($P < .05$ for all) ⁶⁴
Vitamin C	0 to 18 years	1 to 2 g daily	40 days to 28 weeks (typically about 3 months)	Cochrane review of 29 trials found no benefit for preventing colds, but reduced symptom duration by 18% (about 1 to 2 days); starting vitamin C supplementation after symptom onset does not reduce symptom duration ¹⁶

RCT = randomized controlled trial.

Information from references 6, 16, 41, and 59-64.